

private bath, and other features you feel you need. In Rio, Mexico City, Buenos Aires, and most other cities in Latin America, you can get a double room with bath for \$5 to \$10 a night. In parts of Europe you'll pay more. Last time we were in Vienna we paid \$40; in Paris we paid \$35. But in Budapest we got a two-bedroom apartment, with kitchen, for \$9. In Yugoslavia we stayed in private homes for \$6. We've found that, on most trips to Europe, our *average* hotel bill is less than \$20 a night.

In the United States, \$20-a-night hotels are hard to come by, especially in urban areas in the Northeast. Try to stay with friends when you visit Boston, New York, and Washington, D.C. If you don't have friends in those cities, stay in a hotel, cut your visit short, and cram everything in. There's always time to relax later in cheaper, quieter Vermont, New Hampshire, or Virginia.

Whether traveling in the United States or abroad, never make hotel reservations. Hotels that accept reservations have telex machines, computers, and extra reservation clerks. You pay for that infrastructure in the price of your room. Instead, plan to arrive in town at about the noon checkout hour. You'll be able to set up in an inexpensive hotel that doesn't bother with reservations.

I learned this trick on our second visit to Spain. Before leaving home I asked my travel agent to reserve rooms in some of the hotels we had enjoyed on our first trip. To my dismay, none of the hotels accepted our reservation. I assumed they were fully booked. But when we got to Spain we found that those hotels had plenty of rooms. They had denied our reservations because they prefer not to go through the bother and expense of making them.

Since we retired in 1984 Vicki and I have stayed in literally hundreds of hotels around the world. We've never made reservations. And we've never had a problem finding a room.

Savvy travelers suggest that if you arrive without reservations and can't find a room, you head for a local café.